

Write - Up: COOKIES

When I first encountered the picoCTF challenge titled “*Cookies*”, I immediately recognized that it was categorized under **Web Exploitation** and marked as **Easy**. The description hinted at something playful yet technical: “*Who doesn’t love cookies? Try to figure out the best one.*” This suggested that the challenge would involve manipulating or inspecting **HTTP cookies** in a web application.

Step 1: Launching the Challenge Instance

The first step was to click the “**Launch Instance**” button. This opened a webpage titled “*Cookies*” with a simple interface: a text box containing the word “*snickerdoodle*” and a green **Search** button. The page also displayed a message: “*Welcome to my cookie search page. See how much I like different kinds of cookies!*”

At this point, the challenge seemed to revolve around testing different cookie types.

Step 2: Inspecting the Webpage

Since the challenge was about cookies, I opened the **browser developer tools** (usually with Ctrl+Shift+I or right-click → *Inspect*). In the **Application** or **Storage** tab, I looked at the cookies set by the site. Sure enough, there was a cookie storing the current type of cookie being searched (e.g., *snickerdoodle*).

This confirmed my suspicion: the challenge required manipulating the cookie value to find the correct one that would reveal the flag.

Step 3: Modifying the Cookie

I began experimenting by changing the cookie value directly in the developer tools. Instead of *snickerdoodle*, I tried other cookie names like *chocolate chip*, *oatmeal*, and *sugar*. Each time, I refreshed the page or clicked **Search** to see the result.

The site responded differently depending on the cookie value, showing how much it “liked” each type. This trial-and-error process was the key to progressing.

Step 4: Discovering the Flag

Eventually, after testing several cookie values, I found the one that triggered the hidden flag. The page displayed:

picoCTF{y3t_an0th3r_c0Ok13_4dd3d9b9}

This confirmed that the correct cookie value had been identified, and the challenge was solved.

Step 5: Submitting the Flag

Finally, I copied the flag and submitted it in the provided field on the picoCTF challenge page. The system validated it, marking the challenge as completed.

This challenge was a straightforward introduction to **cookie manipulation in web exploitation**. It reinforced the importance of inspecting client-side storage, such as cookies, when analyzing web applications. By methodically testing different values, I was able to uncover the hidden flag and complete the task successfully.